

Gianni Vattimo – amid the crisis in philosophy¹

By

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This paper seeks to explore the relevance of Gianni Vattimo's philosophy for the contemporary discussion concerning the nature and task of philosophy. First of all, an orientation to the question will be given through a review of the sense of crisis that has arisen in recent years concerning the task of philosophy with particular reference to the anti-metaphysical mood characteristic of postmodern philosophy. The paper will then give a presentation of Vattimo's understanding of metaphysics, explain his reasons for rejecting metaphysics and sketch his proposed response of an 'ontology of actuality'. The critical section of the paper will argue that the crisis in philosophy is that of the spirit of modernity with its dialectic of autonomous freedom and autonomous science. An account of the limits of philosophy will be offered in terms of the character of theoretical thought which will provide a platform to assess Vattimo's proposal for a postmetaphysical philosophy. In conclusion some comments will be made regarding the conference theme of 'order'.

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1. *Historical Background*

When we ask “what should philosophy be?” we are asking a philosophical question. Given the penchant of philosophy for scepticism and the pervasiveness of divergent opinions within philosophy it should not be too surprising that its very nature and role should be hotly disputed, even questioned. Yet doubt about the value and purpose of philosophy has grown from Descartes disappointment with the results of his first class education and appears to have acquired an almost unhealthy morbidity.² Descartes tied the fate of metaphysics with that of science, metaphysical problems had to be solved on the basis of a method analogous to mathematics which would in turn found the natural sciences.³ The achievements of Newtonian physics with its mechanistic view undermined notions of human freedom and morality while Hume’s empiricist criticisms of causality in turned threatened the validity of Newtonian science. These conflicts lead Kant to pose the question of the possibility of metaphysics in a direct way. Although he was concerned to show that metaphysics existed, as a natural desire if not as a science, and so must be possible, he conceded that “we can never transcend the limits of possible experience, though that is precisely what this science is concerned, above all else, to achieve.” (Kant 1929, 24, Bxix). His approach to metaphysics therefore involved his so called “Copernican revolution” where instead of knowledge conforming to objects, objects conform to our knowledge. This meant that philosophy should be more circumspect limiting science and knowledge to the phenomenal world while leaving a space beyond knowledge to moral freedom. This still left Reason, grounded in transcendental subjectivity, as universal and sure holding on to its pre-eminent position in the search for truth. Confidence in a particularly philosophical, rather than scientific, reason however became more problematic with the development of science, first the natural and then the human, the success of which removed vast domains from the authority of philosophical reflection. With Nietzsche Kant’s question about the possibility of metaphysics is further radicalised. On the one hand claims about reality in itself are inconsequential because they refer to a world where, as Nietzsche picturesquely puts it, our human head has been cut off. On the other they wilfully ignore what we do experience, a world of appearance or a world, as Nietzsche is fond of saying, “which is the result of a number of errors and fantasies” (Nietzsche 2006, 163, 165). The value of truth now becomes questioned as a “metaphysical value”, and so the value of truth and with it science is made into a problem.⁴

² For Descartes’ disappointment see part one of his *Discourse on Method* (Descartes 1988, 21-25), his comments on philosophy in particular pp.23-24. Roger Lundin finds in Descartes “more than a hint of parricidal desire” and discusses his role as “the authority for all who would live without authority” in “Interpreting Orphans: Hermeneutics in the Cartesian Tradition” (Lundin 1999, 1-64, quotes from page 12 & 13). Peter Schouls has also pointed to the theme of “radical revolution” contained in Descartes projected “reform of science” with its emphasis on “a doctrine of radical epistemic individualism” (Schouls 1980, 38).

³ Metaphysics can be defined in a fairly rough and ready way as an investigation into the nature of reality; in particular its broadest or most essential features usually considered as immutable. Aristotle, in the work later given the title *Metaphysics*, called these features “the first causes” (*aitia*), or “the principles” (*archai*) (Aristotle 1995, 223, 981b28). The line of philosophy in which Vattimo is situated has questioned whether there is a reality “out there” – and later also if there is a reality in us – which has the kind of determinate features which would make claims about reality true or false. Such philosophy we can call “anti-metaphysical”. Descartes own turn to metaphysics, around 1629, involved a rejection of a sense-based epistemology in favour of a more Platonic theory of pure intellectual contemplation and a focus on questions about God and the self.

⁴ For Nietzsche on science as a metaphysical faith see Nietzsche 2006, 363-364 and 1994, 117-120. His question concerning the value of truth is taken up by Barry Allen in his book *Truth in Philosophy* where he argues that

For those who have reflected on developments such as these the question “what should philosophy be?” has come to acquire a certain urgency. The focus of this paper is the contribution of Gianni Vattimo to the discussion of this question. It is offered in the hope that some light might be thrown on the nature of the crisis in philosophy and the options available for its possible future. Before we introduce Vattimo’s account and response to these questions we shall set the stage a little further through considering the issues that are at the heart of the current discussion of philosophy after metaphysics and draw some points from the approaches to these of Richard Rorty and Jacques Derrida.

2. *Setting the stage*

It is important to get clear that despite much talk of the “end of philosophy” there is not a large scale movement of ex-philosophers who have resigned their professorships and are busy encouraging us to stop reading the philosophical classics.⁵ What we have is varying degrees of disease with the traditional claims of philosophy, in particular those regarding Truth and Reason, which has resulted in a bewilderingly wide spectrum of proposals concerning the nature and role of philosophy.⁶ Many are agreed that reason is not autonomous, it does not exist in a platonic realm above this world, but does there not remain a moment of transcendence in an ideal of rational acceptability? There is no isolated, disengaged subject, we are all linguistic-historical creatures, but does that leave meaningful choice a mere effect of culture, are we trapped in our own local language game? Knowledge is culturally formed and socially embodied, but are knowledge and truth no more than forms of desire and power, are exclusion and repression essential components of truth claims or do normative distinctions still hold good? Finally many recognise the presence of metaphor and rhetoric within philosophical discourse but does this break down any meaningful distinction between poetry and philosophy, is philosophy just another literary genre without any special claim to argumentative rigour? These are some of the issues around which contemporary debate about the nature of philosophy revolve. We will now briefly examine some claims made by Richard Rorty and Jacques Derrida to clarify why this can be seen to constitute a crisis in philosophy and the importance of the anti-metaphysical mood of modern philosophy.

On Rorty’s analysis many philosophers have been seduced by the metaphor of the mind as the mirror of nature.⁷ They have seen philosophy as being in a privileged position with respect to reality, having as its task to determine what counts for truth and what value other discourses have in relation to the truth of reality. Rorty wants us to abandon this picture and the project of providing accurate representations of reality in itself, that goes with it. On his account this understanding of philosophy is part of a broader tendency in reflective cultures to “single out

“Far from a contribution, however antithetical, to metaphysics, Nietzsche’s writing exemplifies a scandalous indifference to the specious theoretic universality of metaphysical truth, impersonal and eternal or else entirely without value” (Allen 1993, 50). For Nietzsche’s relation to metaphysics see also Haar 1996.

⁵ Perhaps we should also add that there are also no Francis Fukuyama figures declaring that philosophy has reached its end in the sense of arriving at its *telos* having fulfilled its task.

⁶ The following summary of the debate is indebted to the discussion provided in the general introduction of Baynes et al. 1987.

⁷ This is the focus of Rorty’s “deconstructive” effort in *Philosophy and the Mirror of Nature* (Rorty 1980).

one area, one set of practices, and see it as the paradigm human activity". Rorty continues that "[i]n the mainstream of the Western philosophical tradition, this paradigm has been *knowing*" (Rorty 1980, 366). Yet philosophy can offer no objective, neutral description of the world, it is instead merely a 'literary genre' (Rorty 1987, 27) that finds its starting point, not in nature but, but in distinct particular cultural traditions (Rorty 1987, 54). He holds that its role should be that of "cultural criticism", the philosopher is an "all-purpose intellectual" who moves through different literary genres, sees connections and differences between various ways of seeing things and stitches together a persuasive description that synthesizes the interesting bits of prior descriptions hoping for some temporary usefulness before the next cultural-literary critique offers a more up-to-date version (Rorty 1987, 58). On such an understanding we must admit that "there is nothing down inside us except what we have put there ourselves, no criterion that we have not created in the course of creating a practice, no standard of rationality that is not an appeal to such a criterion, no rigorous argumentation that is not obedience to our own conventions" (Rorty 1987, 60)

If Rorty appears sanguine about the possibility of stepping outside of traditional philosophy into a pragmatist, edifying philosophy, then Derrida is much more cautious, if not outright sceptical of such a move. We are not creators of new descriptions, new language games, for the effects of language are never fully within our grasp. Certainly the conceptual pairs that organise Western metaphysics (sensible versus intelligible, appearance versus reality, becoming versus being, sign versus the thing signified and so on), according to Derrida, do not derive from the nature of things; instead they represent strategies of exclusion and repression where one side of the conceptual pair is given priority over the other. Such priority, according to Derrida, assumes a central reference point which is fixed and so evades the play of differences.⁸ This centre is present in and of itself, it is self-same, and governs structure while in some way being beyond structure (Derrida 1978, 280). Yet something has happened in philosophy, an event connected with the names of Nietzsche, Heidegger and Freud, that signalled "there was no center, that the center could not be thought in the form of a present-being" (Derrida 1978, 280). Nevertheless every critique of this center, of a present-being, remains trapped in a circle. The problem is that any critique of metaphysics must, of necessity, employ the concepts of metaphysics. This is because, writes Derrida, "[w]e have no language – no syntax and no lexicon – which is foreign to this history; we can pronounce not a single destructive proposition which has not already had to slip into the form, the logic, and the implicit postulations of precisely what it seeks to contest." (Derrida 1978, 280/1). Philosophy appears to be an uncircumventable system with a force and efficiency "that regularly change transgressions into 'false exits'" (Derrida 1982, 135). Derrida suggests we have two options. The first is "[t]o attempt an exit and a deconstruction without changing terrain" yet here "one risks ceaselessly confirming, consolidating, *relifting* (*relever*), at an always more certain depth, that which one allegedly deconstructs." (Derrida 1982, 135). The second option, "to change terrain, in a discontinuous and irruptive fashion, by brutally placing oneself outside, and by affirming an absolute break and difference" ends up "inhabiting more naively and more

⁸ Derrida writes "The same, precisely, is *différance* (with an *a*) as the displaced and equivocal passage of one different thing to another, from one term of an opposition to the other. Thus one could reconsider all the pairs of opposites on which philosophy is constructed and on which our discourse lives, not in order to see opposition erase itself but to see what indicates that each of the terms must appear as the *différance* of the other, as the other different and deferred in the economy of the same" (Derrida 1982, 17).

strictly than ever the inside one declares one has deserted, the simple practice of language ceaselessly reinstates the new terrain on the oldest ground.” (Derrida 1982, 135). There is a glimpse of hope in Derrida that instead of opposing itself to its other, philosophy can open itself up to nonphilosophy which, he has said, is “its death and wellspring” (Derrida 1978, 79). Here perhaps there is the potential to be summoned “to a dislocation of the Greek logos” (Derrida 1978, 82), nevertheless a certain fatalism appears to have the upper hand in his thought.

From this brief description of Rorty and Derrida I want to draw out two requirements that can act as criteria for evaluating proposals concerning how we should think of philosophy today. With Rorty we agree that philosophy cannot be thought of as foundational in the sense of the unique discourse or area of culture where we touch bottom and can judge the legitimacy of all and any claims. This is because philosophy is itself part of culture, it reflects on culture and offers its own insights but these should not be thought to rise above culture or be of more value than insights drawn from other cultural practices. This leads to the second requirement, drawing on Derrida, that philosophy must open itself to enrichment from nonphilosophy. In a sense this is not really a requirement but a necessity as philosophy focuses, for the most part, on issues arising from the world around us – there would not be philosophy if there was not nonphilosophy to reflect on. Yet the requirement is to allow nonphilosophy to speak on its own terms, philosophy must respond rather than legislate. Bringing these requirements together we can say that while wanting to hold to the intuition that philosophy can and should have both a critical and enriching role in human culture, this can best be achieved through abandoning a legitimising role and receiving insight from that which exceeds its boundaries. What this means will be elaborated on later in section 7.

3. *Metaphysics: Vattimo’s Definition*

We have seen that an important aspect of the contemporary debate is the question of overcoming metaphysics. This is no surprise as metaphysics here stands for the illegitimate roles and claims that has frequently accompanied philosophy. Therefore a clear definition and rationale for rejecting metaphysics should help clarify the proper task of philosophy. Now Vattimo, who is deeply indebted to Nietzsche and Heidegger in this, has placed their project of a radical critique of metaphysics as “an unavoidable preliminary problem” for philosophy.⁹ What though is metaphysics according to Vattimo? In what does it consist? A number of different statements can be found in his work that answer this question, one of his clearest and most succinct defines metaphysics as “a universally valid description of permanent structures” (Vattimo 1997, 10).¹⁰ This definition contains three elements on which we shall elaborate in turn. Metaphysics proposes to make claims about what is “universally valid”, its mode of

⁹ Vattimo writes “the critique of metaphysics is radical and presents itself as an unavoidable preliminary problem, a real “question of method,” not only where its formation touches on determinate ways of doing philosophy or its determinate subject matter but where it treats the very possibility of philosophy as such” (Vattimo 2007, 402)

¹⁰ This closely parallels what Richard Bernstein has called “Objectivism” which he describes as “the basic conviction that there is or must be some permanent, ahistorical matrix or framework to which we can ultimately appeal in determining the nature of rationality, knowledge, truth, reality, goodness, or rightness.” (Bernstein 1983, 8). It also ties in closely with the critique of the metaphor of seeing as a model for understanding knowledge exemplified in Richard Rorty’s work *Philosophy and the Mirror of Nature* (Rorty 1980).

presentation is descriptive, and it has as its object “permanent structures”.

(1) The first element that makes a philosophy metaphysical in character is the claim to give an objective account of reality free from subjective prejudice and variability. This claim is linked to a certain conception of the knowing subject as impersonal; the subject comes to the object as something opposed and detached; the subject must free itself of all subjective influences which would exclude the possibility of universal validity. So too that which is contingent, for example as a result of historical development or cultural context, must also be removed from metaphysics so that it can guarantee its universal claims. Further the elimination of individual and contingent features of the human subject there is also an exclusion of ambiguity in the content of knowledge which must acquire a clarity and evidentness that is apparent to all potential knowers. The model for this type of knowledge has become entwined, in modern times, with the supposed ideal of the natural sciences to be free of all subjective influences and solely determined by its rigorous logical-empirical method. It is for this reason that metaphysics may be related to scientism which Vattimo has indicated is one of its more recent forms despite its apparently anti-metaphysical outlook.

(2) The model of a rational subject and its corresponding object leads to a philosophical approach that aims to *describe* what actually exists before us in our investigation of reality. Knowledge is understood to be factual and descriptive so that it can be seen to mirror reality, replicating its structure accurately within a clearly articulated theory. Once again there is an appeal to a notion of direct evidence in relation to the object of description. This has the implication that truth must be understood in terms of the correspondence between propositions asserted by the knowing subject and the properties exhibited by the object under investigation. As such the object of knowledge is to be thought of as an independently existing substance, with particular properties, essential and accidental, that can legitimately fall under the scope of a theoretical description.

(3) Despite the apparent changeableness of our experience of the world, the model of an impersonal subject that knows an object with its properties, essential and accidental, allows us to conceive of the world as being structured by permanent features that constitute the order of the world. Metaphysics deals not with the ever changing world we perceive but with a deeper reality that makes this world possible. This is widely considered a key move of metaphysics where another world of unchanging structures is posited as the true real world.

This analysis allows us to see why Vattimo understands the metaphysical appeal to “supposedly direct evidence” (Vattimo 1997, 10) to be a crucial moment in the metaphysical conception of philosophy. It is from this that a number of important corollaries to the above definition gain their meaning, in particular the important place given to self-consciousness in modern philosophy that can be characterised in terms of humanism, and the idea of Being as *Grund* or foundation which guarantees the stability of the structures thought to be uncovered in metaphysics. Now we turn to consider why Vattimo rejects this way of thinking.

4. *Why Vattimo rejects metaphysics*

There are three lines of reasoning detectable in Vattimo’s corpus as to why metaphysics is to

be rejected. The first we will call the ‘historical’ argument. It aims to show that, because of certain historical developments, metaphysics is now both impossible and unnecessary. The second approach we shall designate as a theoretical argument, which is concerned with gaining clarity about the interpretative character of human thought, Vattimo’s appropriation of the notion of ontological difference from Heidegger, and his criticism that philosophy has remained metaphysical in its continual failure to come to terms with its own historicity. The third reason is ethical. Metaphysics is inherently violent and for Vattimo this is the most important reason for seeking a postmetaphysical mode of thought.

(1) Metaphysics is above all about our sense of reality and the role that theoretical thinking, in the guise of philosophy, plays in our ability to apprehend its true essence. Modernity has altered the conditions of belief, and continues to do so even as many have lost faith in its overriding vision. A crucial part of this changing sense of reality has been brought about by the developments of modern science. Its astonishing success and now settled place as a professionalised activity throughout the world has meant that what used to be the preserve of broad visionary amateurs has become more and more specialized and therefore more complex. Such is the vast complexity of modern science that it has become impossible, so Vattimo argues, to practice metaphysics as a foundational discipline that would provide a unifying overview of human knowledge. There just is no one who can know everything, and this would seem to undermine the possibility of the kind of objective view that could lay claim to a universally valid description of reality.

This complexity is not just a feature of our scientific knowledge but also of our social experience. Here we also find ourselves moving from the understandable whole of a relatively enclosed community through a process of differentiation leading to a division of spheres of existence each with their corresponding specific types of logic. At first it may have seemed possible to put this process into a unitary perspective through the notion of the progress of history with Western modernity at the centre, yet such notions of a unitary history have also fallen into disrepute. The arrival of mass communication disseminating an endless plurality of perspectives and local histories, the end of direct colonialism and the critique of the ideological use of history have all contributed to our current incredulity towards metanarratives. Under such circumstances, argues Vattimo, it is impossible to find anything close to a universal unifying perspective needed to found the metaphysical enterprise.

According to Vattimo the effects of modern science, technology and capitalism have lead to a loss of reality which in turn has made the possibility of an objective description of the world impossible. Vattimo explains that “as science speaks increasingly little of objects that can be compared with those in everyday experience, it is no longer clear what to call ‘reality’” (Vattimo 1992, 31).¹¹ This loss of reality has also been induced by the way in which

¹¹ Vattimo allows science to disorientate us without asking why there is such a discrepancy between its results and what we customarily experience in everyday life. There is no investigation into the character of scientific thought, a point which we raise later. This is important because the development of modern science has been accompanied by grand, even utopian, claims about what can be achieved through its application. Nevertheless Vattimo has recognised that the application of science in terms of “technological progress,” accepting its many benefits, can lead to consequences that are catastrophic for life such as to have inspired the great dystopian works of the twentieth-century. See his discussion in “Utopia, Counter-utopia, Irony” in Vattimo 1992, 76-89.

capitalism and technology, in producing artificial worlds of economic transactions and virtual experiences, have blurred any sense of natural needs. Instead desires are forever induced and manipulated by advertisements, and finance becomes more removed from the production of useful goods resulting in a situation where “there is no longer a measuring-stick to distinguish the real from the ‘invented’” (Vattimo 1992, 31). Such loss of a sense of reality though is not to be lamented, for not only is metaphysics now impossible, it is also unnecessary. The reason for this lack of necessity is that the desire for metaphysics rests on the need for calm, the need to make life’s chaos bearable, the need to come to terms with suffering and death. Modern living conditions have largely overcome the precariousness that induced such a desire and therefore makes possible a position of moderation free of “extreme dogmas”.¹² For Vattimo the loss of a sense of reality can and should be seen as a liberation rather than something to be feared.

(2) If metaphysics is about reality, it is also about our knowledge of reality. Once we come to doubt the model of knowledge that has at its centre a purely rational subject observing reality in itself, or at least inferring reality in itself through the use of a rigorous methodology, then our conception of what is real must shift. Nietzsche’s parable of “How the ‘real world’ finally became a fable” is the *locus classicus* for this shift (Nietzsche 2006, 464-465). The movement in philosophy to a focus on the phenomenon of interpretation has highlighted the way knowledge requires a perspective which involves a choice for the knower who is part of the world to be known and not an isolated rational subject set apart from the world. Indeed each knower is historically and culturally conditioned in their approach and so knowing cannot be a pure universal activity with the consequence that “the conception of knowledge as the faithful mirroring of an objectively defined fact “out there” is cast into doubt” (Vattimo 2004, 137)

It is not just the notion of a rational subject that falls foul of a hermeneutic philosophy. This is because we also cannot think of Being as something objective that precedes our conceptual schemes, instead Being “is the aperture within which alone man and the world, subject and object, can enter into relationship” (Vattimo 2004, 6). In viewing Being as ‘event’, Vattimo sees it as essentially temporal. This leads him to reject any nostalgia for Being that is no longer present but may one day return, as Heidegger can be read to do, but also the order of things that currently obtain is just one “sending” of Being and not to be identified with Being as such. In this way Vattimo seeks to be true to Heidegger’s refusal to reduce Being to beings and so preserve the ontological difference forgotten by metaphysics. If we were to reduce truth to correspondence with a stable structure then we would be reducing Being to beings, and would be prisoners of an ideology that identifies “the paradigm or cultural universe into which we are thrown with the real world *tout court*” (Vattimo 1997, 84).

¹² In this context Vattimo often refers to Nietzsche’s notes of 1887 titled “European Nihilism” (Nietzsche 2006, 385-389) the penultimate section of which reads: “Who will be the *strongest* in this? The most moderate, those who have no *need* of extreme dogmas, those who not only concede but love a good measure of chance and nonsense, those who can conceive of man with a significant reduction in his value without thereby becoming small and weak: the richest in health who can cope with the most misfortunes and so have no great fear of misfortunes – men who *are sure of their power* and represent with conscious pride the *achievement* of human strength.”

The upshot of all this is that any postulation of a stable structure is speculative and does not account for the historical and changing character of human life. Yet this is precisely what metaphysics does. Vattimo argues that each philosopher is always responding to contingent questions, yet so often they fail to "address with sufficient radicality their own 'historicity'" (Vattimo 1997, 10). The "historico-cultural" inspiration of philosophy, while more obvious after the fact, often remain hidden, or perhaps masked, by the very form that philosophical argument takes in its appeal to presumed direct evidence. Metaphysics denies its own historicity with its attempt to describe "the world". We should follow the example of Heidegger, suggests Vattimo, who moved away from viewing "the world as a common structure of Dasein to worlds as historical openings of Being" (Vattimo 1997, 24). As we shall see the validity of Vattimo's own proposals must present themselves not as a true description of reality, but as "the most persuasive philosophical interpretation of a situation or 'epoch'" (Vattimo 1997, 10).

(3) The rejection of metaphysics is primarily an ethical position. In this Vattimo is close to the thought of Adorno and Levinas, yet their approach levels the blame against the universal which is believed to trample underfoot the singularity of the individual. Vattimo is more cautious about the equation of universality with violence arguing that metaphysics has sometimes been on the side of the individual with its doctrine of natural right. Instead it is the "incontrovertible presence of Being" that founds violence (Vattimo 1997, 30-31). This incontrovertibility acts as an authority beyond critique. Metaphysics thinks Being as *Grund*, and here we face "the ultimate instance beyond which one does not go and which silences all questioning and thereby closes the discourse" (Vattimo 1997, 85). It is this silencing which is for Vattimo the violence of metaphysics. It is a silencing which can only be presented as something authoritative which demands our submission and which is therefore authoritarian (Vattimo 1997, 85).¹³ Vattimo's project, which he presents as the ethical project of the reduction of violence, becomes designated by the theme of the weakening of Being, or nihilism, precisely because it concerns itself fundamentally with dissolving "the authoritarian and fundamentally violent form in which "foundation" has always presented itself" (Vattimo 2006, 189). Nihilism accepts the positive 'ethical' meaning of the plurality of 'tales' which are to be put to use "in freeing ourselves from both the inflexibility of monological tales and the dogmatic systems of myth" (Vattimo 1992, 26).¹⁴ There is no transcendent objective order, on his account, and so "the imposition of any system of meaning on others is violence and oppression" (Vattimo 1992, 95).

We get a deeper sense of Vattimo's ethical concerns once we see how this argument gets tied together with the previous points. In emphasising the ethical concern of his critique of metaphysics Vattimo explains that "the point is not to counterpose to the vision of Being as objectivity a more adequate, truer conception, which would still be objective, but rather to quit a horizon of thought that is an enemy of freedom and of the historicity of existing." (Vattimo 1999, 31) What can be seen here is the way freedom is closely connected, perhaps even partly identified with the notion of historicity. We can appreciate then why notions of reality as permanent structure, of things having a natural essence are to be opposed with genuine human

¹³ Vattimo writes that metaphysics is the thought "that identifies Being with the objectively given, the thing before me, before which I can only contemplate in silent admiration" (Vattimo 1999, 30).

¹⁴ Vattimo wishes to "take plurality lived explicitly as such as a normative criterion" (Vattimo 1992, 70).

responsibility. Following Nietzsche Vattimo sees the appeal to universal structures as “a sign of profound debility, a depressive phenomenon that strips mankind of all dignity and reduces its every action to a question of divine grace” (Vattimo 2006, 18)

5. Vattimo's response: An ontology of actuality

What then does Vattimo propose? He accepts that metaphysics cannot be simply overcome, or pushed aside as if it were a false opinion, instead metaphysics must be ‘weakened’. This weakening is understood in the relationship between the proliferation of interpretations and the loss of a sense of the really real, in philosophical terms he designates this as the “nihilistic vocation of hermeneutics” (Vattimo 1997, 1-14). As there can be no recourse to the stable structures of Being that would ground a foundational philosophy we must see Being as ‘event’, and as ‘epochal’ and so philosophy, to remain ontological, has to do with a *history* of Being.¹⁵ This means that Being can only be spoken of in terms of the way different historical cultures structure the world of human experience (Vattimo 2004, 6). Vattimo sees the task of philosophy then to reflect on “the new conditions of existence in the late industrial world” and so “to define our place in history” (Vattimo 1991, 1 & 3). This he calls an ‘ontology of actuality’ which he defines as “a discourse that attempts to clarify what Being signifies in the present situation” or an effort to take account of “the ontological ‘significance’ of the present situation” (Vattimo 2004, 3/4).¹⁶ Philosophy cannot take wings in a speculative metaphysics instead it must remain faithful to experience, says Vattimo, and narrate its argument “on the basis on some sort of approximation of general experiential traits that must be assumed to be apparent to all” (Vattimo 1991, 6). Such a narration is what becomes of reason once it has been weakened hermeneutically, which is to say that philosophical argumentation becomes a matter of giving a reasonable interpretation of our condition in the present based on a risky interpretation of our heritage (Vattimo 1999, 45-46).

Vattimo's critique of metaphysics is part of this narrative-historical argument and it leads him to claim that a fundamental feature of the West is a process of weakening of Being from structure to event and with it a weakening of truth claims from description to interpretation. This weakening is seen by Vattimo as having a positive ethical significance because the ‘strong’ characteristics associated with Being led to violence. Giovanni Mari offers a concise summary of how this links together in a hermeneutic philosophy that is closely connected with history:

“Vattimo considers that only on the basis of a historical judgment, precisely starting from a “reconsideration of the relationship between hermeneutics and modernity,” can the “theoretical validity” and “choice” of hermeneutics be

¹⁵ “Ontology is nothing other than the interpretation of our condition or situation, since Being is nothing apart from its ‘event’, which occurs when it historicizes itself and when we historicize ourselves” (Vattimo 1991, 3). In another place he explains that when thinking abandons all reference and justification to clear evidence then “one will at the very least have to speak of Being not in terms of an object or state of affairs, but in terms of ‘event’” (Vattimo 1997, 11)

¹⁶ “Defined as the ontology of actuality, philosophy is practiced as an interpretation of the epoch, a giving-form to widely felt sentiments about the meaning of being alive in a certain society and in a certain historical world” (Vattimo 2004, 87-88). The term “ontology of actuality” is borrowed from Foucault who, in Vattimo's opinion, does not emphasize enough the ontological side of the formulation.

justified. In other words, if “hermeneutics is itself ‘only interpretation’,” it finds its own rational validity, that is, the arguments of its own justification, in that interpretation of history as “destiny of Being,” in a Heideggerian sense, in which hermeneutics appears to be a “moment within this destiny.” In this formulation, history, ontology and rationality appear to follow each other and support each other reciprocally in a radically post-metaphysical style of thought” (Mari 2006, 61-62)

A distinctive feature of Vattimo’s thought in recent years has been his interest in the themes of religion and Christianity in particular. He detects a renewed interest in religion in the cultural atmosphere and so it is appropriate for a philosopher of actuality to reflect on this return of religion. Having seen that he takes nihilism, in the sense of a gradual weakening or dissolution of Being, to be the meaning of our moment in history it comes as a surprise that he also calls Christianity the “guiding thread” within western history. This unexpected link between nihilism and Christianity has informed Vattimo’s understanding of secularisation as carrying forward the Christian message. There are basically three elements of Christianity that inform Vattimo’s secularising interpretation. Firstly the kenotic example of Jesus which he takes to be a renunciation of divine Being and so a paradigmatic event setting in motion the weakening of being that is nihilism.¹⁷ Secondly an emphasis on *caritas*, in particular as more fundamental than truth, understood in terms of the Christian command to love is the ethical meaning of nihilism philosophically expressed as the reduction of violence. Thirdly the evangelical saying ‘I no longer call you servant but friends’ is taken to undercut any authoritarianism which still clings to notions of a transcendent God. Vattimo therefore accepts Nietzsche’s announcement of the death of God as a persuasive interpretation that ultimate values have lost their authority and that the command to love can lead Christianity to embrace the plurality of interpretation that characterises late-modernity. Depoortere has aptly concluded that “Vattimo is turning the Biblical story on God’s kenosis in Christ into a narrative double of his own nihilistic philosophy” (Depoortere 2008, 30)

6. Reassessing the nature of the “crisis”

The anti-metaphysical turn in philosophy developed in two opposing ways. The first challenged metaphysical speculation from the perspective of modern natural science which took the place of metaphysics in providing a rational account of the nature of reality. The claim was that philosophy would be anti-metaphysical if it confined truth to science understood as limited to empirical evidence and focused on the physical world. However as physics developed it came to postulate a world quite different from that of normal experience, and in scientism the claim was made that this world discovered by science is the real world that lies behind and explains, or even eliminates, the secondary reality of our experience. By holding to the truth of a reality more fundamental than our experience, however ‘empirical’ and ‘physical’ its credentials, such scientism remains metaphysical according to the radical critique of metaphysics. The second approach challenged this scientism, perceiving it to be at the root of the colonisation of life by technology and bureaucracy with their forms of control

¹⁷ Vattimo writes that “[t]he only great paradox and scandal of Christian revelation is the incarnation of God, the kenosis – that is, the removal of all the transcendent, incomprehensible, mysterious and even bizarre features that seem to move so many theorists of the leap of faith.” (Vattimo 1999, 55).

and domination that oppress the human subject. Yet this approach also turns out to be metaphysical according to the radical critique because it holds to an essence of what it means to be human. Vattimo recognises this conflict between the two approaches as the crisis of humanism, yet his solution is to accept this crisis as the way towards a renewed sense of emancipation (Vattimo 1991, 31-47). Although he no longer accepts scientism or a humanistic view of the subject yet science and technology live on in his philosophy as part of our destiny and hope for emancipation. He continues to place an unquestioning trust in human autonomy which cannot tolerate the postulation of any meaning or normativity that stands beyond or against the free subject. As such he is unable to see how this ideal of human autonomy in tension with an ideal of rational control (through science) is inextricably bound to the deeper meaning of the sense of crisis in philosophy.

We can see this by briefly returning to our analysis of Rorty and Derrida. Rorty too is captive to the ideal of human autonomy. In asking whether we are conformers or creators¹⁸ he clearly opts for the latter remembering that “there is nothing down inside us except what we have put there ourselves” (Rorty 1987, 60). Here Vaden House is correct to identify as the most crucial element in Rorty’s thought his promotion of “a humanist view of the place of humankind in the world” (Vaden House 1994, 1). His refusal of any supra-human principles means that whatever norms we feel bound to respond to is no more than our own ethnocentric decrees, our resistance to forms of oppression, injustice and human suffering is just the sedimented residue of our ancestor’s preferences. The clash of human ideologies can have no meaning for him, we are left with a form of ethnocentrism¹⁹ and the sense that “something is eternally gained or lost for the universe when we decide for compassion rather than violence, for conversation rather than coercion” (Vaden House 1994, 7) must bow to our own creations as there is nothing else. In claiming that there is no centre, no present-being to ground philosophy, yet also acknowledging that he cannot escape the metaphysical systems he deconstructs, Derrida’s thought also points to the continuing antinomy between human autonomy and controlling rationality.

Here we wish then to point to a deeper level of crisis. What lies beyond questioning is a commitment to human autonomy and what is to be overcome as metaphysics is anything that would challenge this autonomy. Yet human beings have no meaning in themselves. Vattimo recognises this when he says “as soon as I am born I always begin to exist in inauthenticity, I am a finite being and, as such, have a beginning that I can never completely cancel or absorb in processes of self-reflection” (Vattimo 2009, 331). This lack of self-possession is seen by Vattimo as a problem from which we can only hope for a provisional solution in a philosophical recuperation where one takes over what has been given, appropriates it through interpretation and passes it on in a new and modified way. To this spirit of autonomy all must give way or be reinterpreted, including and perhaps especially Christianity. Vattimo cannot contemplate a change of direction on this point which for him could only mean an attempted

¹⁸ Vaden House cautions that for Rorty “Creativity is not creation *ex nihilo* but a reworking and transcending of an existing tradition” (Vaden House 1994, 6)

¹⁹ Rorty concludes his book *Philosophy and the Mirror of Nature* with the following wish: “The only point on which I would insist is that philosophers’ moral concern should be with continuing the conversation of the West, rather than with insisting upon a place for the traditional problems of modern philosophy within that conversation” (Rorty 1980, 394)

reprisal of a past already lost. The crisis within which Vattimo and others continue to think is not that of philosophy per se but of the humanist spirit of autonomy that has pervaded much of modern thought.

7. *The need for a critique of theoretical thought*²⁰

Now it cannot be denied that this crisis as experienced within philosophy and the debate over the end or transformation of philosophy has focused attention on the idea of autonomous reason. It is no longer easy for philosophers to take reason as giving us a unique access to reality in itself, the idol of reason has fallen, or so we might conclude. Yet autonomous reason need not be a matter of making itself something quasi-divine in terms of power and knowledge, autonomy is also a matter of refusing any heteronomy, of refusing anything beyond itself that would give to it meaning or normative direction. Here we wish to refer back to the two requirements we drew from Rorty and Derrida to set a guide for how philosophy should navigate its way through its current sense of crisis. Philosophy must set aside its claim to hold a privileged legitimising position above other cultural practices and discourses and it must open itself to these very nonphilosophical domains of human experience as sources of knowledge and insight.

In order to develop a critique that takes us beyond the dilemmas identified while avoiding a return to metaphysics it will be necessary to arrive at some understanding of the character of theoretical thought which is at work in philosophy. Philosophy, it should be remembered, is an actual activity which arises from within our life and which stands alongside other possible activities. As such, it is a task that generates continuing, provisional reflection by living people. This activity cannot itself be fully encompassed in the results of philosophy, which are theoretical, because such results presuppose philosophical *activity* as its pre-theoretical condition. When we confront the results of theoretical thought with our multifaceted experience of the world we notice its abstract character which contrasts with the concrete richness of living experience. It is part of the nature of theoretical thought to isolate certain realities of our experience and to understand them from a specific viewpoint, for example with respect to its physical momentum, its calculable and measurable proportions, or say its economic value within a given market.

It is a requirement of philosophy to give account in a unified, non-contradictory, way to the full range of human activities and experiences remembering that philosophy too is part of concrete human life. When we speak of the realm of nonphilosophy it is this range of human activity and experience to which we refer. Philosophy must also reflect on the activity and results of the special sciences and help show their connection with human experience without

²⁰ This section takes its inspiration from the philosophy of Herman Dooyeweerd. His student Johan Mekkes wrote the following: "If ever there were a time when we were obliged to begin a search for an answer to the questions about the character and fundamental unity of philosophy, then it is today. The question is: where do we have to look in order to begin to understand? This question is complicated by the fact that philosophy already presupposes the theoretical attitude. Therefore, we have no choice but to start out on our orientation from the *theoretical* attitude of *thinking*. Philosophy derives its meaning from referring to the whole of human life as a unity. In this way it is directed towards the ultimate questions. But it starts from the theoretical attitude of thought." (Mekkes 2010, 3)

ever coming close to comprehending or replacing them.²¹ To recognise the abstracting and isolating character of theoretical thought, including philosophy, helps us to discern when the limits of such thinking are transgressed. From this we can conclude that a philosophical position is metaphysical the moment it makes a claim about the nature of reality that goes beyond the empirical structures of everyday reality. We also must remain vigilant to the temptation of ascribing reality to the abstractions that result from our theoretical analysis. To provide serviceable insight such abstractions must be carefully integrated into a coherent general account of human experience. The reason that philosophy should avoid metaphysics is because once we go beyond the empirical structures of our experience, or oppose them with our abstractions, we no longer know what we are talking about. Our theories start to lose meaning. We can tell whether a claim is metaphysical by working with something like an anti-reductionist verification principle where any proposed hypothesis or concept must have its meaning cashed out in terms of the multi-dimensionality we experience in our everyday knowing.²²

8. *Reordering philosophy after Vattimo*

We wish to agree with Vattimo that philosophy is a profoundly historical task and that it seeks a theoretical perspective that should not be closed in on itself but offer some hope and guidance amidst the issues that face us today. Yet there are a number of problems with his approach that we should like to comment upon. Firstly although Vattimo has acknowledged that philosophy must dwell close to experience he has learnt a suspicion of the evident from Nietzsche which has blocked the way for an account as to how his “ontology of actuality” relates to our actual contemporary human experience.²³ Central to his approach is the rejection of the “principle of reality” understood as “the objective given lying beneath, or beyond” the images and interpretations circulated through mass communication. His interpretation is that “reality is rather the result of the intersection and ‘contamination’ (in the Latin sense) of a multiplicity of images, interpretations and reconstructions circulated by the media in competition with one another and without any ‘central’ coordination” (Vattimo 1992, 7). Despite the apparent value given to multiplicity we find here the isolation of certain specific features of our contemporary experience which can only allow for a narrowed viewpoint. As a consequence many of his observations about our contemporary situation are highly general and are elaborated at a theoretical level with little input from empirical considerations. We give two brief examples to indicate the nature of the problem before drawing our analysis to a conclusion with some reflections on Vattimo’s commitment to autonomy in the context of the theme of order.

²¹ Here we can affirm Vattimo’s call for philosophy to remain faithful to experience and orientated towards proximity (Vattimo 1991, 6 & 169). He cites Nietzsche “the nearest reality, that which is around us and inside of us, little by little starts to display colour and beauty and enigma and a wealth of meaning – things which earlier men never dreamed of” *Daybreak* aphorism 44.

²² A full account of what this would look like requires, among other things, an elaboration of the constitutive role of metaphor in the formation of concepts. This is because metaphor plays a crucial mediating role between our embodied experience of reality and the range and meaning of the concepts that can be formed to account for that reality. See Botha 2007.

²³ Here Vattimo has been forthright in identifying the crucial problem saying “[t]he real difficulty is to define the sites and forms of knowledge that represent the “objects” of an ontology of actuality” (Vattimo 2009, 342).

In his approach to Christianity, it is noteworthy that Vattimo still gives philosophy the crucial legitimating role.²⁴ He writes that “[philosophy] must grant legitimacy to religious experience, though only insofar as it recognizes the end of metaphysics” (Vattimo 2002, 88).²⁵ By claiming that hermeneutics is the philosophy of modernity, and that modernity fully accounts for our historical position, he is able to give this philosophy *exclusive* right over religious experience. Vattimo’s whole exposition of Christianity, as he himself acknowledges is “led by certain conclusions elaborated at a philosophical level” (Vattimo 1999, 60). Where he feels it necessary to offer critique of official forms of Christianity it is based on what is “no longer *theoretically* tenable” (Vattimo 1999, 62, emphasis added) and he refers in this context to “reason as the criterion of truth” (Vattimo 1999, 59). What this reveals is a continuing theoretism in Vattimo’s philosophy where what is presented as a “risky interpretation” nevertheless achieves a certain universal validity to pronounce on valid forms of religiosity for today. This universal claim however gained its validity only because of his philosophy, so for those unconvinced by his philosophy such pronouncements can hold no authority, at least without anticipating the very authoritarianism that it rejects.

A similar issue arises in his treatment of history. Vattimo has argued strongly against any linear conception of history (Vattimo 1992, 1-11) and yet his account of nihilism and secularisation appear to be just that. He has responded to this charge by reminding us that what he offers is not a *description* of the objective development of history, but an *interpretation* that is to be preferred over others. It is to be so preferred, not due to its fidelity to the facts but because of its ethical vocation to reduce violence (Vattimo 2009, 336-337). Nevertheless even as an interpretation his reading of modernity is still too totalising in the way it ignores alternative voices and traditions, his fear of offering anything that would seek to account for the facts, because of its inherent objectivism, excuses him from any responsibility to the complexity and heterogeneity of the past. What is required here is a more calibrated critical awareness of the complexity of cultural dynamics the normative requirements of which cannot be read along the line of a single thread of Nihilism or secularisation, however weakened such a reading claims to be. That our social world involves a complexity of logics beyond the grasp of an all seeing reason need not obviate the need for a fully articulate ontology of actuality to be sensitive in its interpretations of simultaneous movements of differentiation, integration, and individuation across the plural structures that characterise modern societies.

Vattimo’s commitment to human autonomy means that it is taken as a primary datum in his philosophy so that norms and principles appear on the scene ‘after the fact.’ Their appearance can then only be interpreted as alien to this primary datum, as being *enforced* on human autonomy, and so they carry an inevitably repressive and authoritarian character. Vattimo therefore rejects all appeal to norms as inherently violent.²⁶ To point out the presence of this

²⁴ The exposition and critique of Vattimo’s engagement with Christianity presented here and earlier in this paper should be seen as a preliminary sketch that while critical in tone should not be seen to exclude the possibility of a more positive appreciation.

²⁵ “From the perspective of religious experience, the actuality of hermeneutics, which with good reason regards itself as *the* philosophy of modernity, means that for us, more than in past epochs, salvation takes place through interpretation” (Vattimo 1999, 60)

²⁶ “Violence for me is ... an act of imposition on the other and her liberty” (Vattimo & Girard 2010, 45).

humanistic ideal of autonomy in his thought is not to chide Vattimo for he is free to hold to such a view, what we can and should object to, though, is the surreptitious elevation of this ideal to a philosophical axiom. Equally we are free to explore the alternative perspective that norms are primary, with human responsibility and freedom being secondary, to explore whether such a starting point can better account for our experience. It has been the vocation of reformational philosophy to work from out of this perspective by articulating a view of normative principles as pointing and directing the way to blessing and human flourishing. One result is that it is the *enforcement* of these norms that is unacceptably violent rather than the norms themselves.²⁷ The point about principles is that they ‘hold good’, they make a claim on us, we cannot make a claim on them; to claim a principle is to immediately distort it under the influence of ideological ends. Those in authority have no special privilege in interpreting norms, indeed precisely in their position of authority they are *subject* to responsibility in the actualization of norms so that their actions are all the more open to critical evaluation. Principles such as justice do not merely call for a response, they are such a call, and as such they do not provide some eternal model that has to be realized.

Vattimo is correct to worry about an appeal to norms that have the effect of ending the dialogue about human responsibility, that is why it is important to emphasize their *primary* status as *starting*-points. The call of norms is at the start of the conversation, they open up the possibility of human responsibility and the need for dialogue as to their realization. Here we touch upon their deeply temporal character. For example in the call for justice a direction, a way, is pointed out, casting light on the first steps that need to be taken. Principles are historical in that they only gain traction in a given situation which is why they leave in the dark any final destination. It is the striving after goals and clear ends that leads to the ideological distortion of principles because then they become co-opted as means to the pre-determined end. There is a ‘metaphysical temptation’, driven by the pretension to rational autonomy, to place principles within our theoretical purview, but to do so oversteps our capacities. Nevertheless we cannot avoid their obstinate, mysterious character as they call, within human experience, for greater realization.

9. Conclusion

Having emphasised the temporal character of normative principles and the role played by human activity to actualise these in historical contexts we are willing to affirm the task of philosophy in terms of an ontology of actuality. On the basis of the preceding analysis however we have to conclude that Vattimo has not succeeded in giving a convincing account of philosophy as an ontology of actuality. The strengths of his account – a rejection of the objectivism of metaphysics, an ethical concern for the reduction of violence, an acknowledgement of the historicity of philosophy – are thought through in a rigorous way. Nevertheless they are each worked out in problematic ways leading to an antiseptic attitude to the vicissitudes of empirical reality, a commitment to human autonomy that cuts short discussion of a diversity of normative requirements, and an understanding of historicity that

²⁷ I do not mean to deny that competent authorities within organisations and social institutions should not enforce appropriate rules and procedures governing the exercise of certain tasks and activities. Such enforcement of rules are themselves responses, better or worse, to norms which themselves cannot be enforced because they are beyond human control and can only be responded to.

dissolves all structures that would limit autonomy. So while philosophy should recognise that its task is deeply historical it should not thereby reject any notion of a non-arbitrary normative order, indeed the temporal character of such an order requires the cultural-formative actions of actual human beings, including those who engage in philosophy, to re-order our world in ways that brings blessing and flourishing to the rich variety of people and the multiple tasks engaged in daily.

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